Why are Christian video games deemed preachy?

Case Studies Into the Formal Elements of Christian Entertainment Software and How They Affect Player Engagement.

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First edition, Tuesday 10th March, 2026

To John Doe

Some more descriptive text.

Acknowledgements

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Abstract

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1

Introduction

1.1 | Motivation

1.2 | Aims and Objectives

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1.3 | Our Approach

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1.4 | Document Structure

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2

Background & Literature Overview

2.1 | What are Christian Video Games?

In an interview, games scholar Kevin Schut states that currently, there is no consensus on what defines a Christian game (Faith Forms, 2024, 8:38). This becomes apparent when one examines online discussion around the topic. For example, one of the factors that Moon Channel (2023) considers when determining if a video game is Christian is that it must promote Christian morals. Meanwhile, Hartgrove (2022) considers *Hypnospace Outlaw* (2019) a Christian game primarily because its creator, Jay Tholen, identifies as a Christian[1]. Within the same interview, Schut also seems to imply that the definition is subject to change, given that the use of the label is undergoing constant cultural negotiation (8:50, 24:26). Therefore, before conducting my study, I needed to establish a static working definition of "Christian video games".

2.1.1 | Existing Definitions

Earlier work by Schut (2013) gives us a good starting point for such a definition. Based on a series of interviews with seventeen Christians working in the game industry, he outlined four definitions of "Christian Games". Explicitly Christian Games "feature Bible stories or passages, very clear presentation of the gospel message, and stories that very openly have a Christian worldview". As an example, Schut raises *Big Bible Town* (2010), a video game which aims to teach children about Bible stories. Meanwhile, Allegorical Christian Games "have stories that are not necessarily openly Christian but have Christian themes or messages underneath them" (p. 137). Interviewees mentioned no instances of such games, but they cited the Narnia series by C.S. Lewis as an example of this style.

[1] Although Hartgrove does discuss the game's content somewhat, he does not deem explicit ideological content as necessary.

Interviewees also raised what Schut terms as Evangelical Christian video games, which "focus on sharing the gospel with people who aren't Christians". (pp. 137–138). However, this is only a hypothetical definition since Schut could not cite an examples. Lastly, Christian-friendly games, such as Bejeweled and Words With Friends, are "clean and safe, without significant violence, adult sexuality, swearing, anti-Christian worldviews, and other things that Christians might find offensive or disturbing" (p. 137).

Schut's work also gives valuable insight into how the term "Christian Games" is used. For example, he notes that most of the interviewees commonly defined "Christian Games" as either Explicitly Christian Games or Allegorically Christian games. However, only few of them considered Christian-friendly games part of the genre. Based on these observations I could have based my definition on the most common uses of the term. However, there was one issue which made me hesitant to do so — the ambiguous use of the term "Christian".

While the distinction between "Christian" and "non-Christian" outlooks or morals may seem trivial, there have been disagreements in the past. For example, Gonzalez (2014) talks about *The War In Heaven* (1999), a first-person shooter which has been criticised for allowing players to play as demons. She points out an anonymous review in which the reviewer argues that the game does not teach the Bible in the right context (p. 209). Nevertheless, the developers defended this inclusion, stating that "[their] design is in accordance with Biblical teachings" (p. 204).

Subsequent work by Schut (2026) acknowledges the subjective application of this term (p. 310), and clarifies his use of the term "Christian". While there are various groups which could be described as Christian, Schut observes that the Christian media industry in North America is influenced primarily by Evangelicals. He attributes their dominance to their collective focus on proselytism and their eagerness to adopt new media technologies as a means to that end. However, he also remarks that Evangelicals have not always counted for the majority of North American Christians, and that they are still garnering a presence in most other countries. Furthermore, he also notes that other groups, such as Roman Catholics, have also produced Christian games. Consequently, he clarifies that, within the context of Christian video games, the term "Christian" is often synonymous with "Evangelical", though this is not always the case.

Within the same study, Schut continued to investigate the ways in which Christians have employed the term "Christian genre". He found that, occasionally, Christians have argued that video games with Christian authorship are Christian games. However, after

a brief survey of the types of video games which players have described as Christian, Schut concluded that Christians typically use the term to disclose the presence of Christian ideology within a video game. However, Schut does not provide a more detailed, formal definition which I could use for my research.

Gonzalez (2014) corroborates Schut's claims about Christian video game production. By compiling a comprehensive list of religious video games she demonstrated that the overwhelming majority of these games had Evangelical associations. However, unlike Schut, Gonzales does not opt to define Christian games for her research. Instead, she defines "religious games" to study Evangelical video games within the broader picture of playful religious software. Using "agential realism" as an ontological frame, Gonzales describes something as "religious" if it stages interactions between human and non-human beings (p. 24), such as angels and demons.

Based on this definition, she excludes games like *Castlevania* (1986) from her study, which include typically religious materials to embellish their fictional world. She does this because these games do not depict the non-human others as agents with which borders must be negotiated, but as imaginary entities. Similarly, she disregards games such as *Run, Jesus Run!* (2010) or *Crucify-me! Jesus* (2000), which utilize religious material in a derisive or critical manner, since these negotiate boundaries between human groups. Furthermore, Gonzales limits her study to religious organizations, which she defines as a long-lived alliance of human and non-human entities which jointly determine the borders of humanity.

While this definition is more rigorous than either of Schut's definitions, my original research question does not concern games associated with religions unrelated to Christianity. Therefore, I could not use it for my research. However, her definition of religious organisations proved useful as inspiration for my own definition, which I explain in the following section.

2.1.2 | My Definition

2.2 | Related Work

2.3 | Summary

3

Materials & Methods

This section should include a recipe of what you did (explain what you have done so if someone wants to reproduce the experiment, they can). Should also include a description of statistical methods used (if any).[1]

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3.1 | Summary

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[1]For more information see: `http://rc.rcjournal.com/content/49/10/1229.short`. Last Accessed: 27th November, 2024.

4

Results & Discussion

Should include a reiteration of the experiments, and their outcome. Together with a description (discussion). Preamble should include a reminder of the aims and objectives together with a list of experiments to achieve these. Should include many charts and other visualization with appropriate descriptions.[1]

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4.1 | Summary

[1] Another footnote example.

5

Conclusions

This section should have a summary of the whole project. The original aims and objective and whether these have been met should be discussed. It should include a section with a critique and a list of limitations of your proposed solutions. Future work should be described, and this should not be marginal or silly (e.g. add machine learning models). It is always good to end on a positive note (i.e. 'Final Remarks').

5.1 | Revisiting the Aims and Objectives

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5.2 | Critique and Limitations

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5.3 | Future Work

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5.4 | Final Remarks

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A

Media Content

If the dissertation has a DVD or pendrive attached to it, you will need a section which explains what is on the media (structure, files, data, etc.). This could be a table with filename and description.

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B

Installation Instructions

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C

User Manual

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